

downloading from their website. Microsoft Windows XP has built-in options to manage and configure networking. However, support for WPA2 and some other security protocols require updates from Microsoft. XP has a strange way of connecting to the wireless network. In case there is a problem regarding the wrong passphrase for closed networks, it keeps connecting without notification that the passphrase is wrong. There are a few other problems as well. But for the generic user, Windows support is sufficient to connect and work with a Wi-Fi network, although more picky users might be insistent on getting their own driver and software support. Vista has improved Wi-Fi support as does Windows 7 (the release candidate at least).

Getting set up is easy
and before long you'll
be able to browse
wirelessly

Linux, FreeBSD and similar Unix-like clones have support for Wi-Fi though this is not very standardised as the very nature of these platforms is open source. Linux has patchy Wi-Fi support, though native drivers for many chipsets are available at little or no cost. Since open source is not as prolific as it could be, many small hardware manufacturers skip making drivers for Linux.

Let's try setting up a wireless network and connecting to the internet using it. We assume that you neither have the hardware capability nor the drivers installed and so we shall begin from scratch. Users who possess just the first or both may proceed from wherever necessary in case they wish to go through the workshop. This tutorial will serve several purposes: installing a Wi-Fi device, setting up a Wi-Fi network and connecting to the internet via a bridged network. Wi-Fi hotspots work on the same principle.

We shall begin by assuming that you have Windows XP Service Pack 2 installed. Also, that you have or will soon purchase an external device that will allow you to access Wi-Fi. Wi-Fi dongles (small piece of hardware) are available in USB format or using PC slots. You may choose either.

The steps that you need to follow are the following

- Choose your wireless equipment.
- Connect your wireless router.